

CLASSROOM COMMUNITY • LOW-STAKES CONVERSATION

Question of the Day

Silly questions, strong opinions, and an easy reason to start talking

A short pre-class routine that helps students get to know one another, share an opinion without worrying about a correct answer, and become comfortable talking before mathematical work begins.

Building Community Through “Question of the Day”

TEACHING PRACTICE

At the beginning of many class meetings, I pose a short Question of the Day for students to discuss with the people sitting near them. Some questions help students learn a little about one another; others are intentionally ridiculous and invite an entertaining disagreement.

The goal is not the question itself. These conversations give students an easy, low-stakes reason to speak before I ask them to discuss mathematics. Over time, talking with classmates becomes a normal part of class rather than something that begins only when a mathematical problem appears.

1
CONNECTION

Students learn small, memorable things about the people around them.

2
CONVERSATION

There is no correct answer, so everyone has an easy entry point into discussion.

3
PARTICIPATION

A familiar low-stakes routine makes later mathematical conversation feel more natural.

How I use it

- Put one question on the board as students arrive.
- Give students a minute or two to discuss it with the people sitting near them.
- Invite a few answers or reactions from the room when a question produces a particularly good debate.
- Transition into mathematics once students are already talking.

Sample Question Bank

GETTING TO KNOW YOU

- What's your most useless talent?
- What's a completely useless fact that you know?
- What is something you believed for way too long?
- What is something you are weirdly competitive about?
- Which country would you like to visit most?
- What's something on your bucket list?
- What's the strangest thing you've ever eaten?
- What inanimate object would you want to be?

EVERYDAY OPINIONS & PREFERENCES

- Do you unpack your suitcase immediately or live out of it for several days?
- Do you shower in the morning or at night?
- When you're watching TV, do you use subtitles?
- Do you sleep with your bedroom door open or closed?
- What is your favorite way to eat a potato?
- What is the correct number of pillows to sleep with?
- What is the best shape?
- What is a completely insignificant hill you are willing to die on?
- What is your favorite fish to: touch, have, be, eat.

SILLY SCENARIOS

- If you had to use a vegetable as a weapon in combat, which vegetable are you choosing and why?
- Which do you think you could throw farther: a baguette or naan bread?
- What is the least amount of money you would accept to eat a spider?
- If you had to swap your legs with the legs of any animal, which animal would you choose?
- Which day of the week would win in a fight?
- Without any extra equipment, how many pigeons do you think you could reasonably carry?
- If you had to replace your hands with kitchen utensils, which two utensils would you choose?
- What is the largest animal you think you could pick up?
- Would you rather have to fight one goose every month or ten geese once a year?
- Which condiment would be the worst to swim in?
- You have to hide a giraffe. Where are you putting it?
- Which pasta shape would win in a fight?
- You have \$10 to spend at a gas station. What are you buying?
- How many five-year-olds do you think you could beat in a game of tug-of-war?
- Do you think you could catch a squirrel with your bare hands if you had an entire day?

Students get a chance to laugh, disagree, and explain their reasoning before I ask them to do those same things with mathematics.